

S01-L4 — Galleries and Fairs: the Primary Market, the Secondary Market, and How to Prepare for a Fair

Summary

The commercial circuit of the art world is organized around two markets with distinct logics: the primary market, where a gallery sells new work by a living artist at a price it sets itself, and the secondary market, where a work that has already changed hands at least once is resold, whether at auction or through a dealer. According to the *Art Basel and UBS Global Art Market Report 2026*, dealers and galleries generated a larger volume of sales in 2025 than the auction houses did, confirming that the gallery channel, combining primary and secondary activity, remains the center of gravity of the art business in aggregate size.¹ This handout describes that distinction, examines the case of a gallery that institutionalized a unit dedicated exclusively to the secondary market, reviews the fair calendar that matters most to a sales advisor based in New York, and closes with the pricing discipline practiced by one of the sector's megagalleries.

1. Primary and secondary: two different businesses under one roof

The primary market is the direct sale between a gallery and a buyer of a work appearing on the market for the first time, usually by an artist the gallery formally represents. The gallery sets the price, decides who has access to the work, and manages the waiting list when demand outstrips supply. The secondary market, by contrast, is the resale of a work that has already circulated, and there public auctions coexist with the private sales run by the auction houses themselves and with galleries that buy and resell secondhand inventory.

The Art Basel and UBS report on 2025 quantifies that distinction at a global scale. Dealers and galleries generated 34.8 billion dollars in sales during 2025, a 2% year-on-year increase, while [global public auction sales totaled 20.7 billion dollars](#), up 9%, and private sales declared by the auction houses themselves stayed below 4.2 billion, a 5% decline.² Adding both auction-house channels together, the combined auction sector still falls several billion dollars short of the volume moved by galleries. It is a figure worth keeping in mind when a client

equates the "art market" almost exclusively with the auction room, when in reality more than half the business happens behind a gallery's doors.

2. When a gallery plays both boards: the Perrotin Second Marché case

The boundary between primary and secondary has become less clear-cut in recent years, as large galleries have started operating their own resale units. The most cited case in the sector is Perrotin, which created a separate division called Second Marché, dedicated exclusively to the secondary market. Its co-directors, Tom-David Bastok and Dylan Lessel, explained at an industry symposium that [the unit was born after observing that even major collectors received fragmented attention](#): one person at the gallery sold them new work, while someone else entirely, often outside the gallery, handled buying back or reselling work they already owned.³ Bastok noted further that responding only with a consignment option can lose the client when they ask directly whether the gallery is willing to buy the work outright, which is why Second Marché keeps its own acquisition capacity in addition to taking consignments.⁴ Lessel, for his part, described a three-step verification routine, "check, double check and triple check," on authenticity and provenance before committing to any valuation or purchase.⁵

3. The fair calendar that structures the semester

For an advisor working with Latin American collectors from New York, three dates anchor the year. The first is [The Armory Show, confirmed for September 24 to 27, 2026 at the Javits Center](#), the semester's kickoff after the August lull and the first opportunity for early demand-reading ahead of the November auction season.⁶ The second major concentration arrives in December, with Art Basel Miami Beach, which sets its VIP Days for December 2 and 3, 2026 and opens to the public from December 4 to 6 at the Miami Beach Convention Center.⁷ Around that same week, satellite fairs such as NADA Miami, Art Miami, Design Miami and Untitled Art cluster together, making the first week of December the single densest stretch of client encounters on the annual calendar.⁸

4. Pricing discipline in the primary market: the Pace case

One of the risks of the primary market is that a young artist's prices rise too fast and lose sustainability once initial interest cools. Marc Glimcher, President and Chief Executive of Pace Gallery, explained that the gallery [adjusts its young artists' prices carefully, in increments of roughly 10% a year](#), a practice meant to protect the artist's career from price jumps that become hard to defend later on.⁹

It is a useful reference for explaining to a client why the price of an emerging artist's work does not always climb as fast as they might expect.

5. Preparing a client before stepping onto the fair floor

The difference between an improvised visit and a well-prepared one comes down to the work done beforehand. Art advisor Esthella Provas described [reading the PDFs galleries send ahead of a fair's opening, taking notes, and sharing that selection with clients to agree on priorities before arriving](#).¹⁰ Provas also explained that during the first days she prioritizes the galleries where she expects the most competition for sought-after works, since those pieces tend to sell early, and only afterward reserves time for open-ended discovery.¹¹

For the conversation with clients

- When a client asks whether it is better to wait for the November sale or buy earlier at a fair, the answer starts by explaining that these are two different markets: at the fair the gallery sets the price and access runs through relationship, at auction the price is set by public competition in real time.
- For a client who only pays attention to auctions, it is worth reminding them that more than half the volume of the art market runs through galleries, not auction rooms, and that primary-market channel is also where long-term relationships tend to get built.
- Before taking a client to a major fair, it is worth applying Provas's logic: review participating galleries' material in advance and work out a priority order with the client based on which works are most likely to sell early.

References

1. Art Basel and UBS, ["Global sales rise 4% to \">\\$59.6 billion in 2025, amid ongoing market recalibration"](#), *Art Basel and UBS Global Art Market Report 2026* by Clare McAndrew, Arts Economics, 2026. ↵
2. Art Basel and UBS, ["Global sales rise 4% to \ \\$59.6 billion in 2025, amid ongoing market recalibration"](#), 2026. ↵
3. Talking Galleries, ["Notebook 9, Barcelona Symposium 2022"](#), transcript of *Galleries in the Secondary Market*, 2022-10-03/04. ↵
4. Talking Galleries, ["Notebook 9, Barcelona Symposium 2022"](#), 2022-10-03/04. ↵

5. Talking Galleries, ["Notebook 9, Barcelona Symposium 2022"](#), 2022-10-03/04. ↵
6. The Armory Show, [official site](#), accessed 2026-08-08. ↵
7. Art Basel, ["Self-Guided Tour Rules & Regulations"](#), Miami Beach, accessed 2026-08-08. ↵
8. New Art Dealers Alliance, ["NADA Miami 2026"](#), accessed 2026-08-08. ↵
9. Art Basel, ["Marc Glimcher: 'It's not just about what's new - it's about what lasts'"](#), 2025-06-09. ↵
10. Art Basel, ["How art advisor Esthella Provas gets ready for Art Basel Miami Beach"](#), 2024-11-29. ↵
11. Art Basel, ["How art advisor Esthella Provas gets ready for Art Basel Miami Beach"](#), 2024-11-29. ↵